

Of travel scams and fake QR codes

BEWARE OF THESE FIVE KEY RISKY TRAVEL PROPOSITIONS

Jayesh Shinde | jayesh@digit.in

The Great Indian Summer is here – the season of midnight flight bookings, endless Skyscanner tabs and WhatsApp marathons about the perfect beach. Not just for travelers across India, it's also the peak hunting season for cyber-crooks. McAfee's new India Safer Summer Travel Research, based on a February 2025 survey of more than 7,000 adults (including 1,000 Indians), shows how easily a dream vacation can morph into a data-breach nightmare.

1 The bargain instinct is a double-edged sword

Nothing unites Indians like a great discount, and scammers exploit it better than your local kiranawallah. McAfee found that 86% of us research common cons, yet 47% still fall for them. One in five victims lost more than ₹40,000 – often the entire holiday kitty. Millennials and Gen Z travellers (25-34) are hit hardest: 31% clicked malicious "confirmation" links and 25% believed doctored photos promising Maldives but delivering Madh Island. If the copy screams "unlimited luxury at 70% off," assume the only thing unlimited will be headaches.

2 IPL tickets: cricket's newest minefield

Cricket season turbocharges both travel and tricksters. Eighty-two

percent of Indians heading to marquee sporting events worry about fake tickets, and for good reason: QR-code cloning and bot-driven reselling platforms flourish. McAfee's data shows 23% of fans don't know how to spot a fraudulent link, even though 60% promise to be more cautious this year. If your backup plan involves WhatsApping "Cricket Bhai" for last-minute passes, beware!

3 Scams look startlingly legit

Forget cartoonish misspellings; today's spoof sites mimic the real thing pixel-for-pixel, SSL certificate and all. As much as 22% percent of respondents clicked unknown "confirmation" e-mails, 19% entered card details on look-alike portals, and 10% chatted with "travel planners" who vanished faster than an in-flight snack. On holiday the pain continues: 21% paid deposits for rentals that didn't exist, 18% booked excursions that never materialised, and 12% faced identity theft after passports were swiped at faux reception desks. Assume crooks already know your wish-list – and are designing traps to match it.

4 QR codes aren't cute, they could be attack vectors

Quick-response squares are everywhere: restaurant menus, boarding

passes, payment counters. Ten percent of Indian travellers had boarding-pass QR codes stolen, gifting hackers a neat bundle of personal and flight data ripe for dark-web resale. Toss in shady public Wi-Fi, imposter hotel "staff," and overshared Insta stories, and a beach break can morph into a logistical hellscape. Best practice: scan only official codes, verify shortened URLs, use a VPN, and save that sunset selfie for later.

5 Awareness isn't action

We discuss scams in every family WhatsApp group, yet 51% of Indians have either been duped or know someone who has. Why? Trip-planning fatigue, FOMO, and the stubborn belief that "it won't happen to me." "Verify sources, pay only through secure gateways, and treat too-good-to-be-true offers as red alerts," advises Pratim Mukherjee, Senior Director of Engineering at McAfee. His simplest tip: never mix travel planning with a distracted mind or a dying phone battery.

At the end of the day, stay vigilant while planning your next vacation. Travel, explore and cheer for your team – but don't let a ₹500 discount cost you your identity. Digital hygiene belongs on the packing list right next to sunscreen and chargers. Safe journeys start with healthy scepticism. 